that the NLD was a communist front, and he was replaced by Aung San Suu Kyi. Tin Oo remained involved in the NLD, and he represents the extent to which the leadership of the NLD was embedded in Burma's elite,[40] having been forced to resign as commander in chief of the army in 1976 after a failed coup and when his wife was accused of taking bribes.

In effect, the NLD emerged as a coalition of three different elements of Burmese society. It had links to the military, in particular those who had fallen out of favour in the various factional disputes that occurred after 1962. In Aung San Suu Kyi, it embodied the linkage back to General Aung San and those who had hoped for a secular, civilian Burma. Finally, it attracted the electoral support of the students, monks and other Burmese struggling against the military, but had limited popular appeal outside the ethnically Burman communities.[41] This led to a very particular type of organisation. On one hand, it was an elite party representing two slightly divergent elements in the Burmese elite, and on the other hand it became a mass party almost by accident.[42] As we will see, this has left the NLD very dependent on the Buddhist monks, as they form the link between an elite leadership and the popular masses[43] and this, in turn, has severely limited the NLD's appeal outside the Burman ethnic majority.

In the run up to the 1990 elections, many of the opposition supported the NLD, but equally, most ethnic groups organised their own regional parties. In Rakhine, the Arakan League for Democracy (ALD) emerged as one of these local parties, but they only accepted membership from Rakhine Buddhists, deliberately excluding the Rohingyas, and called for the establishment of ethnically Rakhine communities in the north of Arakan.[44] The successor to this party, the Rakhine Nationalities Development Party (RNDP) was to be instrumental in organising the 2012 massacres.[45] Thus, unique among the patchwork of ethnicities and political movements, the Rohingyas were severely impeded from having any direct representation in the elections (and, due to the citizenship laws, most were denied the vote). Despite this exclusion, an important side note for us is that in the 1990 elections some ethnic Rohingyas were allowed to organise their own political party and even won some seats.[46] And the decision to allow some Rohingyas to stand in 1990 was the result of the regime's interpretation of its own citizenship rules,[47] allowing Rohingyas with identity cards issued in 1982 to vote or stand for election.